







A PLANET IN CRISIS (clockwise from far left) a still from *Dear Future Children*; posters of *Against the Tide*, *The Leopard Tribe* and *We Are Guardians*

CINEMA

CINEMA FOR **ENVIRONMENT**

The fourth edition of the **All Living Things Environmental Film Festival** will see screenings of offbeat films across India

There are "no David Attenborough-style nature documentaries" at the All Living Things Environmental Film Festival (ALT EFF), says co-founder and director Kunal Khanna. Instead, there will be films on Russian scientists transporting large woolly beasts to Siberia, dwindling orca populations, and space trash. The fourth edition of ALT EFF will screen 62 films, from December 1 to 10, online and offline across India. Thirty-nine films are Indian premieres.

Since its inaugural 2020 edition, ALT EFF has come a long way from being a digital endeavour. "Films on environment and climate change solutions are becoming more prominent as you can see with the reception for *All That Breathes*, *The Elephant Whisperers* and *My Octopus Teacher*, all of which won Oscars since 2020," says Khanna. "Our festival is 50 per cent about cinema, as are all film festivals, and 50 per cent about conversations, workshops, and real-life changes regarding climate change, which is affecting everyone across the globe." Khanna plans to start a fund to encourage filmmakers to make environmental cinema.

Films hosted on the ALT EFF website (alteff.in) can be accessed for free as well as through a pay-as-you-feel model. Feature-length, shorts, animated films as well as student films are included in the roster.

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In the International Features section, there is *Pleistocene Park*, in which Russian geophysicist Sergey Zimov and his son Nikita aim to restore the Ice Age "mammoth steppe" ecosystem and avoid a feedback loop leading to runaway global warming, by getting their hands on any large woolly beast they can find and packing them off to the most remote corner in Siberia. *Space Trash* follows how millions of pieces of trash are hovering in outer space at breakneck speed, which, if not removed, will lead to the collapse of space exploration and communication systems.

The 2021 Hot Docs winner *Dear Future Children* follows three young activists from Hong Kong, Uganda and Chile and examines the impact on their lives.

Indian features include Sarvnik Kaur's *Against the Tide*, winner of the 2023 JIO MAMI Mumbai Festival's top prize. The film tracks two fishermen friends from Mumbai's Koli community as a dying sea drives them to pursue different livelihoods. *Morisika: The Story of the Boatman* traces the personal histories of eight people whose lives are intertwined with the Brahmaputra River across the 19th, 20th and 21st centuries. *The Leopard's Tribe* throws light on protests against the Maharashtra government's plan to build a metro car shed project by deforesting the Aarey forest, home to the 10,000-strong Warli tribe that worships leopards.

Among shorts, Sourav Sarangi's *Tiger Army* tracks the foot soldiers protecting tigers in the Sundarbans. *Chao Carbon* exposes energy corporation AES Gener's harmful impact on Chile. In Japanese-Canadian animated short *The Floating World*, a student discovers sustainable living practices from history that can be applied today after being transported into a 19th-century Edo painting. Experimental short *Terra Mater* has a technological junk goddess angrily accusing one and all for destroying the planet. ■

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